Oderbruch near the Polish border. This kind of activity dispelled any doubts about Honecker's physical stamina and showed the FDJ not to be just a theoretical organisation but a practical one. By March 1947, it boasted 425,000 members, with 1,500 young people elected to municipal and district parliaments and thirteen members to state parliaments. In works council elections, over 8,000 young people became members, 80 to 85 per cent of whom were supporters of the FDJ.18

While in terms of visible achievements, Honecker's work life was remarkably successful, his home life remained turbulent. He endured an anxious period after Charlotte spent the winter in virtual seclusion under treatment for neurological problems, aggravated by heavy depression. A physician brought to the house was glum. There was nothing to be done except for his ailing wife to remain in bed. For the next few months, Honecker nursed Charlotte, administered medication, and read to her late into the night. But when her condition took a turn for the worse, she was moved to the St Joseph's hospital where she died on 6 June 1947, physicians said her passing was due to 'degeneration of the brain tissue'.

For years after, her medical records, death certificate, autopsy and burial details were closely guarded. As Ed Stuhler observed, 'it was as if this woman had never existed on paper'. In an attempt to wipe the slate clean, this awkward union was airbrushed from Honecker's life – with no mention made of Charlotte in biographies or his memoirs. Remarkably, though, a wedding certificate was unearthed by Stuhler at a registry office in Berlin in 1991. 'It is genuine. Honecker has done everything possible to cover up this marriage,' Stuhler told the author. 'It certainly is curious how it managed to survive the incinerator.'

After Charlotte's death, Erich Honecker engaged on several official foreign trips showing himself to be a gracious guest and enthusiastic tourist. Over the coming years, he displayed a genuine appetite for travel and wherever he happened to be, a few hours of his day were spent exploring. In Bucharest, he padded across the 'Little Paris of the Balkans,' where enough of the past lingered to give it the charm of tradition. He delighted in the sunlit boulevards and wooden houses hiding in the shadows of concrete buildings, and small white churches nestled beside modern apartment